1 The Six Trigonometric Functions

Central question. How do six functions arise naturally from the same moving point on a circle?

1.1 From a point to six functions

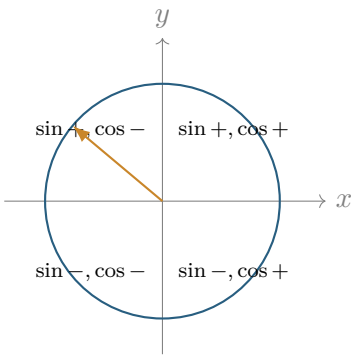
Last week we studied the unit-circle point $P = (x, y) = (\cos\theta, \sin\theta)$. The two coordinates determine four additional ratios whenever the denominators are nonzero:

$$\sin\theta = y, \quad \cos\theta = x, \quad \tan\theta = \frac{y}{x},$$
$$\csc\theta = \frac{1}{y}, \quad \sec\theta = \frac{1}{x}, \quad \cot\theta = \frac{x}{y}.$$

These are not six unrelated measurements. They are six different ways of reading the same geometric information.

Definition 1.1. The *tangent* function is $\tan\theta = \sin\theta/\cos\theta$ where $\cos\theta \neq 0$. The functions csc, sec, cot are the reciprocals of sin, cos, tan respectively, wherever defined.

Example 1.1. At $\theta = \pi/3$ the circle point is $(1/2, \sqrt{3}/2)$. Thus $\tan\theta = \sqrt{3}$, $\sec\theta = 2$, $\csc\theta = 2/\sqrt{3} = 2\sqrt{3}/3$, and $\cot\theta = 1/\sqrt{3} = \sqrt{3}/3$.



1.2 Signs and the quadrants

The coordinate signs determine every trig-function sign. In quadrant I both coordinates are positive; in II, only sine is positive; in III, tangent is positive because both coordinates are negative; and in IV, only cosine is positive. Reciprocal functions have the same signs as their corresponding original functions.

Example 1.2. For $\theta = 5\pi/4$, the reference angle is $\pi/4$ and $P = (-\sqrt{2}/2, -\sqrt{2}/2)$. Therefore $\tan\theta = 1$, $\sec\theta = -\sqrt{2}$, and $\csc\theta = -\sqrt{2}$.

1.3 Where are the functions undefined?

Division by zero has no meaning. In particular, $\tan\theta$ and $\sec\theta$ do not exist where $\cos\theta = 0$, at $\pi/2 + k\pi$. Similarly $\cot\theta$ and $\csc\theta$ do not exist where $\sin\theta = 0$, at $k\pi$, for any integer k. The word *undefined* matters: an undefined value is not the number zero.

Try it. Find all six trig-function values at $\theta = 3\pi/2$, identifying every undefined value.

1.4 Right triangles are a special case

For an acute angle θ in a right triangle, scale the triangle so its hypotenuse has length 1. The opposite and adjacent sides then give the coordinates $\sin\theta$ and $\cos\theta$. Restoring a general hypotenuse h gives

$$\sin\theta = \frac{\text{opposite}}{h}, \quad \cos\theta = \frac{\text{adjacent}}{h}, \quad \tan\theta = \frac{\text{opposite}}{\text{adjacent}}.$$

The unit circle is more general than the right-triangle definitions: it handles negative angles, obtuse angles, and angles exceeding a full revolution.

Example 1.3. A ramp rises 1.5 meters over a horizontal run of 6 meters. Its angle of inclination satisfies $\tan\theta = 1.5/6 = 1/4$. Therefore $\theta = \arctan(1/4) \approx 14.0°$.

1.5 Special angles without memorizing a disconnected table

An equilateral triangle of side 2 splits into two right triangles with sides $1, \sqrt{3}, 2$. This produces $\sin 30° = 1/2$ and $\cos 30° = \sqrt{3}/2$. A square of side 1 has diagonal $\sqrt{2}$, producing $\sin 45° = \cos 45° = \sqrt{2}/2$.



1.6 Applications: orientation and measurement

Suppose an observer stands 40 m from the foot of a vertical tower. The angle of elevation to its top is 35°. The tower's height h satisfies

$$\tan 35° = \frac{h}{40}, \qquad h = 40\tan 35° \approx 28.0 \text{ m}.$$

Here the tangent function links an angle to a ratio of lengths. Always sketch the physical situation and label which distances are opposite and adjacent before calculating.

1.7 Exercises

1. At $\theta = 2\pi/3$, find all six functions exactly.
2. At $\theta = 7\pi/4$, find $\tan, \cot, \sec, \csc$.
3. Explain geometrically why $\tan(\pi/2)$ is undefined.
4. For which angles in $[0, 2\pi)$ is $\csc\theta$ undefined?
5. A right triangle has opposite side 5 and adjacent side 12. Find all six trig ratios exactly.
6. A ladder leans against a wall, reaching 8 m high. Its foot is 3 m from the wall. Find the angle with the ground.

7. A drone is viewed at an elevation angle of 28° from a point 75 m horizontally from the point below it. Estimate its altitude.

8. Show that $\sin^2\theta + \cos^2\theta = 1$ implies $1 + \tan^2\theta = \sec^2\theta$ wherever $\cos\theta \neq 0$.